

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH

BA (HONOURS) 4TH YEAR FINAL EXAMINATION QUESTION BANK

COURSE CODE: E 405

COURSE TITLE: Semantics and Pragmatics

Target Stream: Concentration on Applied
Linguistics & ELT

Batches Included: 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50 (Batch 45 missing)

CURRENT SYLLABUS REFERENCE & SCOPE (Session: 2021–2022, Batch 51)

SEMANTICS:

- **Introduction:** Defining meaning; Meaning of 'meaning' (Ogden & Richards); Levels of analysis; Leech's 7 types of meaning.
- **Key Notions:** Sense, reference, and denotation; Proposition; Ambiguity (lexical & structural); Lexical vs. grammatical meaning; Componential analysis; Lexical sense relations (synonymy, antonymy, hyponymy, meronymy, polysemy, homonymy).
- **Theories of Meaning:** Structural, behaviourist, cognitive, truth-conditional, and generative theories; Necessary & Sufficient Conditions (NSC) model; Prototype Theory; Family Resemblance.
- **Figurative Language:** Metaphor, irony, polysemy, metonymy.

PRAGMATICS:

- **Introduction:** Scopes & traditions (Anglo-American vs. European Continental); Everyday language features; Sentence vs. utterance; Context; Entailment & presupposition.
- **Implicature:** Conventional and conversational implicature; Grice's Co-operative Principle; Conversational maxims (Quality, Quantity, Relation, Manner); Flouting maxims.
- **Deixis:** Deictic centre & projection; Deictic vs. non-deictic expressions; Types of deixis (person, time, place, discourse, social); Honorifics.
- **Speech Act Theory:** Performatives vs. Constatives; Felicity conditions; Austin's trichotomy (locutionary, illocutionary, perlocutionary); Searle's typology (Representatives, Directives, Commissives, Expressives, Declarations); Indirect speech acts.
- **Politeness & Conversation:** Face wants; Positive & negative face; Politeness strategies; Conversational analysis (Adjacency pairs, turn-taking, repairs).
- **Interface & Discourse:** Semantics-pragmatics interface; Cohesion and coherence.

SECTION A: BROAD QUESTIONS — SEMANTICS

Descriptive and theoretical essay questions covering the study of meaning, sense relations, and semantic analysis.

Semantics Essay Questions

1. Differentiate between words and sentences as semantic units. How do lexical meaning and grammatical meaning contribute to the interpretation of a sentence? Support your answer with examples. [50]
2. Explain and exemplify the seven types of meaning identified by Geoffrey Leech (Conceptual, Connotative, Social, Affective, Reflected, Collocative, Thematic). [49, 48, 46]
3. Define semantics as a level of linguistics. What are the major levels of analysis of meaning in language? Discuss. [48, 46]
4. What do you understand by 'sense' and 'reference'? Discuss lexical sense relation analysis as a semantic approach for analyzing meaning in language. [48, 46]
5. Explain the concepts of cohesion and coherence in semantics and their crucial role in text comprehension. [48, 46]
6. What is semantics? Define meaning in the light of Ogden and Richards' definitions of meaning. Explain the levels of analysis of meaning in language. [47]
7. What is 'lexical role analysis'? Give an account of 'conceptual meaning' and 'connotative meaning'. [47]
8. How is semantics different from pragmatics? Why is the study of meaning most difficult compared to the study of the other aspects of language? [46]
9. Differentiate between lexical meaning and grammatical meaning. How does 'componential analysis' help us understand the meaning of lexical items? [46]

SECTION B: BROAD QUESTIONS — PRAGMATICS

Descriptive questions exploring speech acts, implicatures, presuppositions, conversational dynamics, and context.

Pragmatics Essay Questions

1. What does 'pragmatics' deal with? Discuss with examples the key features and properties of everyday language use. [50, 49, 47, 46]
2. What is 'implicature'? Discuss with examples the different types of implicatures (conventional vs. conversational). [50, 48, 47]
3. What do you understand by 'presupposition'? Illustrate some of the lexical items and linguistic constructions that trigger presupposition. [50, 48]
4. Compare Searle's illocutionary act category of Directives (e.g., requests, commands) with the concept of an adjacency pair from Conversational Analysis. How do both frameworks explain the way an initial utterance is designed to elicit a specific response from a listener? [50]
5. Write on the scopes of studying pragmatics. How does the Anglo-American tradition of pragmatics differ from the European Continental tradition? [49]
6. What does conversational analysis refer to? Discuss the features of conversation that conversational analysts figure out and interpret (turn-taking, adjacency pairs, repairs). [49, 47]
7. What does Austin mean by performatives and constatives? How and why does he shift from this dichotomy to Speech Act Theory? [49, 47, 46]
8. What is implicature? Discuss co-operative principles and the associated conversational maxims postulated by Paul Grice. [48]
9. Analyze the role of speech act theory in understanding communicative meaning. Discuss Austin's trichotomy and Searle's taxonomy of illocutionary acts. [48, 46]
10. How is implicature different from presupposition? Write with examples on different types of implicature found in language use. [47]
11. What is deixis? Discuss with examples different categories of deixis (person, place, time, discourse, social). [46]

SECTION C: SHORT NOTES & BRIEF CONCEPTS

Short explanatory notes covering semantic and pragmatic principles.

Short Notes Collection

1. Semantic-pragmatic interface [50]
2. Deixis and Deictic Origo [50, 46]
3. Necessary and Sufficient Conditions (NSC) model in prototype theory [50, 49]
4. Implicature and conversational maxims [49]
5. Categories, subcategories, and exemplars [49]
6. Presupposition triggers [49, 47]
7. Sentence meaning versus utterance meaning [48]
8. Semantic roles (Agent, Patient, Theme, Instrument, Experiencer) [48, 46]
9. Flouting of conversational maxims [48]
10. Transactional and interactional functions of language [48, 46]

11. Hyponymy and hypernymy [47]
12. Cohesion and coherence [47]
13. Grice's Maxims (Quantity, Quality, Relation, Manner) [47]
14. Levels of meaning analysis [46]
15. Honorifics as social deixis [46]

SECTION D: PRACTICAL CASE SCENARIOS & PROBLEM-SOLVING EXERCISES

Applied problem-solving tasks involving semantic feature matrices, semiotic triangles, prototype theory, and real-world discourse ambiguity.

Binary Semantic Feature (BSF) Calibration: Diplomatic AI Scenario [50]

Context: A tech company is developing an AI for diplomatic and corporate negotiations. The AI struggles to differentiate between the titles 'king', 'president', 'CEO', and 'monarch', often using them interchangeably and causing diplomatic incidents.

Tasks:

- a) Using the concepts of **descriptive meaning** and **denotation**, explain why these terms are conceptually distinct despite sometimes referring to a single individual.
- b) Propose a set of binary semantic features to distinguish these four lexemes: [±HUMAN], [±ADULT], [±HEREDITARY], [±GOVERNMENTAL], [±CORPORATE], [±HEAD OF STATE]. Complete a feature matrix using '+' for presence, '-' for absence, or blank if not applicable.
- c) Evaluate the efficacy and limitations of this feature-based approach in unravelling complex semantic structures.

Semiotic Triangles: Morning Star vs. Evening Star [50]

Task: Analyse the statement *"The Morning Star is the same celestial body as the Evening Star"* using three semiotic triangles:

1. For the general term 'planet'
2. For the descriptive phrases 'the Morning Star' and 'the Evening Star'
3. For the full sentence itself.

Explain how each triangle provides insight into descriptive meaning and truth conditions. How does the analysis reveal that two different concepts (senses) can share the identical referent (Venus)? Discuss the roles of meaning, denotation, reference, Context of Use (COU), and truth value.

Categorization Debate: Botanist vs. Chef (Tomato Case) [50]

Scenario: A botanist states: *"Based on its structure, developing from the flower's ovary and containing seeds, a tomato is unequivocally a fruit."*

The chef retorts: *"In my world, it's a vegetable. Its flavour profile is savoury, not sweet, and it belongs with onions, not apples."*

Tasks:

- a) Analyse the botanist's argument using the traditional **Necessary and Sufficient Conditions (NSC)** model of categorisation.
- b) Analyse the chef's argument using **Prototype Theory**. Explain how a tomato can be understood as a marginal, non-prototypical FRUIT, yet a prototypical VEGETABLE.
- c) Using Wittgenstein's concept of **family resemblance**, explain how tomatoes, carrots, and spinach all belong to the category VEGETABLE without a single shared property.

Gricean Maxim Flouting in an Interview Context [50]

Scenario: An interviewer asks a job candidate: *"So, what did you think of your last boss?"*

The candidate, who strongly disliked their previous boss, replies: *"She was very punctual."*

Questions: Which of Grice's conversational maxims is the candidate flouting (Manner, Quantity, Relation, or Quality), and what is the conversational implicature generated?

Corporate Memo Ambiguity & Disambiguation Scenario [49]

Memo: "All staff must complete their annual performance reviews by Friday. Delays may lead to consequences, including potential demotions, reassignment of duties, or other actions at the discretion of management."

Tasks:

- a) Identify and explain different types of ambiguity (lexical, syntactic, temporal) in the memo.
- b) Discuss **homonymy vs. polysemy** regarding terms like 'consequences' and 'duties'.
- c) Explain disambiguation techniques management should apply to make communication precise.
- d) Analyze the role of the **Principle of Consistent Interpretation** and context in resolving meaning shifts.

Ancient Manuscript Binary Semantic Analysis [49]

Using binary semantic features [+/-EDIBLE], [+/-TOOL], and [+/-LIVING], categorize and analyze relationships between recovered lexical items (e.g., *apple*, *stone*, *saltwater*, *knife*) and evaluate the strengths and boundaries of componential feature analysis.